

Don't Pass the Sugar

Bollywood is in the midst of a gang war, where words are weapons and everyone is a soft target. Award shows, interviews and blogs, it's a free-for-all as stars indulge in candid confessionals.

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

For years, when they smiled their orthodontically perfect smiles and uttered their saccharine sweet homilies, the world made gagging sounds. How could everyone in Bollywood be one big happy family? Did they not covet each other's films, paycheques, girlfriends, and sometimes, wives? But now, Bollywood's greatest myth has taken a beating. The masks have dropped and the daggers are drawn. In the war of words, everyone is a free target of free speech.

It all started in 2004 with *Koffee with Karan*, where Bollywood insider Karan Johar encouraged his guests to drop their guard and be themselves. That often meant being mean, whether it was Farah Khan calling Sanjay Leela Bhansali the most overrated director or Kareena Kapoor saying that John Abraham was

expressionless. But it was a cosmetic irreverence. Friends were completely excluded from such slingshots.

Now others have shown they too can play the game. Confrontation, some real, some concocted, has become filmdom's fashion statement for the summer. Amitabh Bachchan is leading the charge with a blog that daily makes news, generously providing enough headlines for half-hour specials, sms polls and analytical discussions. Where once there was just one great rivalry between the Shahenshah and the Badshah, now there are several little face-offs in play. So Salman Khan now stipulates to any studio he is in talks with that he should get Rs 5 crore more than Akshay Kumar. Kumar has been advised by close friends to pit himself against Shah Rukh Khan if he wants to be crowned the new king of Bollywood—after all, he can take

over only if the current occupant either abdicates or is dethroned. Which explains why he wastes no opportunity to nudge Shah Rukh: "You don't need to be a Khan to be a superstar", or "I don't need to own a team to promote cricket".

Adding to this free-for-all is Aamir Khan, who plainly believes in plainspeak, whether it is telling an interviewer why he thought *Black* was an awful film or writing in his blog about his smelly dog named 'Shahrukh'. That's not all. Cut to Ajay Devgan and Shah Rukh. While the latter got snarky about him on *Koffee with Karan*, Devgan vented his bile on Khans dancing at weddings and protesting for a cause in *Halla Bol*. Everyone has a pet

AKSHAY KUMAR

You don't need to be a Khan to be a superstar.

AAMIR KHAN

'Shahrukh' is licking my feet and I am feeding him biscuits.

SHAH RUKH KHAN

Aamir and Salman are my friends. We play strange pranks on one another.

AMITABH BACHCHAN

'Paanchvi Fail', as a rival channel executive calls it, is facing low ratings.



Photo montage by SAURABH SINGH and PRASHANT CHAUDHRY